

Project Self-Assessment

Sergio Monterroso — The Piedmont Hotel

I came to class early on the morning of January 31st when we were set to visit the UNG Special Collection and Archives Department. To pass the time, I opened the Finding Aid for our archives and found a collection donated by the Longstreet Society which held the certificates of appointment for James Longstreet. I had absolutely zero clue who James Longstreet was and even less so of the American Civil War, but the documents of such importance still intrigued me. I still had time to kill so I opened JSTOR and searched for an article on this historic individual. This superficial research led me to the Piedmont Hotel, which engrossed my life for the next few weeks until the final compilation of an academic photo guide to digest the messages of the hotel and its guides.

Project Purposes

The project originally began with a video to advertise the Longstreet Museum, but that was made difficult by the museum itself. Not only would the museum undergo remodeling soon, rendering any photography useless for a video project, but the museum's structure and teaching was entirely incorrect — but incorrect in a good way. In the beginning, I entered the project to help the museum but as our class progressed and taught me to gauge the messages behind each curatorial decision, I just could not continue and maintain good faith. So, the purpose of the project changed.

The audience of the current academic photo guide is meant for individuals that have or are soon visiting the Longstreet Museum that are interested in a digest of the messaging behind the exhibits, rooms, and messages there. This excludes those that are interested in fueling their Lost Cause tank with nostalgic *Gone with the Wind*-esque nostalgia but is instead targeted towards individuals like me when I first started this class: those who were inclined to history and its study but not absorbed by the lessons of public history and the political mantra that haunts it. It is meant to guide those that are *truly* inclined to learn history but need a guiding hand to spank away the nostalgia in favor of a more academically approached view of the museum. Truthfully, this guide is meant for myself to digest what I had missed when I first began my work at the Piedmont Hotel.

My goal in this academic guide is to lead visitors away from the mistakes I made in my first few visits. In these visits, I looked at the Longstreet Museum as a simple civil war museum that needed help reaching visitors to teach a story of a character with many contours and breaks from the traditionally accepted civil war history. It became clear to me that the rooms and texts of the Longstreet Museum are politically charged to sanitize the Confederacy with a “civil rights activist Confederate General” instead of sanitizing a Reconstructionist Republican from his Confederate service. In my academic guide, I refer to the Piedmont Hotel as a memory site to infiltrate civil war discourse to propagate a new theory in the Lost Cause: that the Confederacy was not about slavery or white supremacy because it had a Lieutenant General, James Longstreet, that “fought” for equal rights. By missing this message in my first message, I unknowingly gave credit to this theory and now make this guide to warn other visitors to not make this mistake.

Methodology & Sources

My project involved research into two parts: the research into James Longstreet’s biography and of the Piedmont Hotel itself. For the first part, I relied mostly on Elizabeth Varon’s book *Longstreet: The Confederate General Who Defied the South* (2023) and some of her academic papers on Longstreet’s life. I also used the microfilm machine in the UNG Dahlenega Library to look at newspaper articles in the New York Times and The Dahlenega Nugget that covered Longstreet while he lived in Gainesville or New Orleans. Though most of this research did not land in the final project, it was necessary to get me where I could produce a product viable for public consumption.

I encountered a few roadblocks in my work, many of them self-imposed that required a moment of soul-searching. This project began as a video advertisement for the Longstreet Society, but eventually I found myself having trouble featuring the society in a way that does not compromise ethics. How can I make a video with someone like Richard Pilcher in the center while still maintaining an academic touch to it? It is impossible. Around this time, I requested a meeting with Dr. Hightower over the approaches I could take a video, but the entire meeting became obvious that I had to juggle various interests to produce a video. Eventually, with the news of a summer remodel in the Piedmont Hotel, I had an opportunity to shift from a video

project to an academic photo guide using the pictures I had taken of the Piedmont Hotel for my video project.

I have learned more about the field of history in this one project than in my years of reading academic journals. I interacted with actual “history” and all of the interpersonal disputes involved with juggling multiple interests. Is history meant to tell a story? Is it meant to be used as a tool of the future? Is it just to record down dates and events? There is no objective answer to the question but this project exposed me to all sides of the discourse: the storytelling of Richard Pilcher, the use of James Longstreet for Lost Cause iconography, and the researching of dates using primary sources like newspapers. Something that began with me scrolling JSTOR and the Finding Aid for the UNG Special Collections and Archives Department led me to an interesting brush with history in action.

Concluding Thoughts

I am still somewhat unsatisfied with where I landed in this project. This project was meant to be executing a form of public history, but I ended up doing a mixture of academic history being taught to a *somewhat* public audience. The guide is fifteen pages long and while I tried to minimize the text as best as possible, there are still wordy parts that make reading the guide unappealing for public consumption. I understand that I tend to ramble on and enjoy listening to my own words: this self-assessment is now three pages long because of that. But I also struggled to minimize the lessons that we learned in this class into brochure size. I still feel that it would be doing the reader an injustice to not go into depth about the messaging of the Longstreet Museum — but if you go too far, you scare the reader away. I need to reflect on this more and get better at weighing what to sacrifice.